



“We have to take Mission Gaganyaan forward, build our own space station and also land Indians on the moon. Your experiences will be very helpful”

—NARENDRA MODI
Prime Minister of India, talking to Shubhanshu Shukla in space

the past five decades, it has fulfilled its objectives of indigenously building rocket launchers and satellites for development purposes at reasonable cost. These include satellites for telecommunication, remote sensing, navigation and even defence. Now, the prime minister wants India to venture to the final frontier by joining the big league, putting crewed missions in space.

Since Yuri Gagarin’s historic first spaceflight on April 12, 1961, in a Soviet Vostok 1, only three countries—US, Russia and China—have had their own crewed spacecraft. While the US and Russia are veterans, China joined this exclusive club on October 15, 2003, when it launched Shenzhou-5, its first crewed spacecraft. Since then, China has launched 13 other crewed missions and established the Tiangong-1 space station, a permanently crewed research platform, in 2011. When it completed its three modules in 2022, the new Chinese space station, also called Tiangong, measured about half the length of the ISS. The country has also set an ambitious goal to land its astronauts on the moon by 2030.

India, on its part, had initially focused on sending unmanned missions to the Moon and Mars. However, in his first term, Modi decided India must make the big leap towards human spaceflight and exploration. He sanctioned the Gaganyaan project in December 2018 to send up a crewed orbital mission by the first quarter of 2027. Simultaneously, Modi cleared the building of the first module of the Indian orbiting space station—Bharatiya Antariksh Station or BAS-1—by 2028. The combined cost of Rs 20,193 crore is among the single largest budgets set aside for an ISRO programme.

The prime minister didn’t stop at that and enunciated a longer-term vision for a project that will facilitate the landing of Indian astronauts on the moon by 2040. Shukla, in that sense, is the first Gaganyatri in India’s new space odyssey. As Modi told Shukla, “Today, I can say with confidence that yours is the first chapter of success of India’s Gaganyaan mission. India is opening the doors of new possibilities of space for the world. India will not just fly, but will prepare the platform for new flights in the future.”

Conscious of the nation’s enormous expectations of ISRO, Dr V. Narayanan, its chairman, who had just returned to the space headquarters in Bengaluru after participating in the launch of the Ax-4 mission, told INDIA TODAY, “Gaganyaan is a national project that not only involves ISRO but also the Indian navy and air force, apart from a whole host of industries in the public and private sector.”